

“Are you saying that we should sell our home and move to a cheaper one?” Ben asked.

“I’m not going to tell you to do anything, I’m just going to point out some logical alternatives. Then you’ll have to make your own choices. I know that you get attached to your home—often a woman especially—and giving it up is a difficult decision.”

“Not for me,” Naomi said quickly. “I’ve always viewed that house as an anchor around our necks. It was Ben who really wanted it in the first place.”

“That’s probably true,” Ben said. “But the guys at work said it was stupid to pay rent when I could buy a home and get all the tax breaks.”

“Usually that’s pretty good logic—but not when you wreck your budget to buy. It would be better to rent and stay within your income than to buy and end up in debt,” Mr. Stanford said. “I believe you could potentially free up hundreds of dollars a month by renting for a while.”

“That much!” Ben exclaimed. “That would be enough to pay our tithes and more. I guess I never realized the house was putting us into that much debt. I always thought of it as a good long-term investment.”

“For most families it is. But only after they have settled into a lifestyle and found a home within their budget. Buying a home too quickly and one that is too expensive is the number one reason most young couples end up in financial trouble.”

“But why doesn’t someone tell people those things before they make the mistakes we made?” Naomi asked.

“In our society people make money off the excesses of others, unfortunately. However, there’s a verse in Proverbs that presents the principle I’m talking about. I have it written on a card—Proverbs 24:27: ‘Finish your outdoor work and get your fields ready; after that, build your house.’ That means do the preparation first, before you plunge ahead before you’re ready.”